

Lab: Building Muscle Memory, Hook by Hook

Objective

Experience the learning process directly by attempting a new stitch, tracking your skill development through repeated practice, and calibrating your gauge through systematic swatching.

Materials

- Worsted weight yarn, approximately 40 yards
- Two crochet hooks: one in your usual size (e.g., H/8 / 5.0mm) and one size larger (e.g., I/9 / 5.5mm)
- Ruler or tape measure
- Timer or phone
- Pen and Learning Log (template below)
- Scissors

Learning Log Template

Trial	Time to Complete Row	Error Count	Tension Rating (1-5)	Ease Rating (1-5)	Notes

Steps

Part 1: Baseline — Familiar Stitch (10 minutes)

1. Using your usual hook and yarn, chain 16 and work 3 rows of single crochet (15 sc per row). Time yourself on the third row only. This is your baseline speed for a well-learned stitch.
2. Rate the ease of this row on a scale of 1-5 (5 = completely automatic). Record in your Learning Log.

3. Count errors (dropped stitches, uneven tension, miscounts). For a familiar stitch, this should be close to zero.

Part 2: Learning a New Stitch (25 minutes)

1. Choose a stitch you have **never done before** or rarely attempt. Good options:
2. **Front Post Double Crochet (FPdc)**: yo, insert hook from front to back around the post of the stitch below, yo, pull up a loop, [yo, pull through 2 loops] twice.
3. **Puff Stitch**: [yo, insert hook, yo, pull up a loop] 3 times in the same stitch (7 loops on hook), yo, pull through all 7, ch 1 to close.
4. If both are familiar, choose any stitch you have not practiced.
5. **Trial 1**: Chain 16. Attempt a row of the new stitch. Time yourself. Count errors. Rate ease (1-5) and tension consistency (1-5). Record everything. It is okay if this row is messy — that is the point.
6. **Trial 2**: Chain 16 again. Repeat the same stitch. Time yourself. Record errors, ease, and tension. Compare to Trial 1.
7. **Trial 3**: One more row. Time, record, compare.
8. **Trial 4**: A fourth row. By now, you should notice improvements. Record.
9. Review your Learning Log. Plot (mentally or on paper) the trend: is time decreasing? Are errors decreasing? Is ease increasing? This trend is your generative model refining itself in real time.

Part 3: Gauge Calibration as Prior Updating (15 minutes)

1. Using your usual hook (5.0mm), crochet a gauge swatch: chain 16, work 8 rows of sc.
2. Measure: how many stitches per 4 inches? How many rows per 4 inches? Record this as your **prior gauge**.
3. Now switch to the larger hook (5.5mm). Crochet a second gauge swatch with the same yarn: chain 16, 8 rows of sc.
4. Measure the second swatch. Record as your **updated gauge**.

5. Compare: how did changing the hook size change your gauge? Did the change match your prediction? If you predicted "the larger hook will give me fewer stitches per inch," was your generative model correct?

Part 4: Reflection and Discussion (10 minutes)

1. Review your Learning Log from Part 2. Identify the trial where the biggest improvement occurred. What changed between that trial and the previous one? Was it a specific insight, or a gradual smoothing?

Discussion Questions

- During the new stitch trials, did you feel prediction error decreasing with each attempt? At what point did the stitch start to feel "natural"?
- When you switched to the larger hook for gauge calibration, how quickly did your motor model adjust? Did the first few stitches feel strange before your hands recalibrated?
- In your crochet circle, compare learning curves: did everyone improve at the same rate on the new stitch, or were there differences? What might account for these differences in terms of prior experience and generative model depth?
- How does this lab change your understanding of what it means to "practice" crochet?

Wrap-Up

You have experienced learning in real time: the awkwardness of a new stitch becoming smoother through practice (precision tuning), and the systematic calibration of gauge through swatching (prior updating). Keep your Learning Log and gauge swatches for reference.